Payphone Go Part 1

2 March 2026

Abraxas3d and Prey Animal with Odessa

The Route:

Stop 1 Plan: Santee Trolley Square (9888 Mission Gorge Rd). Take the 56 east to the 52, then south on the 67. Scan the perimeter of the shopping center and near the trolley/bus stops. Outdoor phones near transit will be the best bet.

SBC
To
El Cajon

Stop 1 Reality: Barnes and Noble! Bought books. Oh look, a massive Miniso store! Argued with Prey Animal about blind boxes. Prey Animal thought payphone should be at the bank. I thought it should be at the trolley stop. This time, I was right.

5·10·25
U.S.
COINS
ONLY
COIN RELEASE
DOMESTIC
CALLING
FREE
FOR 5 MINUTES
NO
INCOMING CALLS
PUBLIC PHONE
1. LISTEN FOR DIAL TONE 2. DIAL NUMBER 3. CONNECT CALL
2872 MISSION GORGE RD
COLLECT
CALLS TO
at&t
Dial
*91
CASH CALLS
OPERATOR ASSISTED CALLS
CALLING CARD & COLLECT CALLS
FAST CALLS
PUSH
FOR
COIN

SBC
SBC

We attempted to play the game. This means dialing the 888 683 6697 game number and then waiting for a prompt (we assume) to enter player ID. Calling the 888 number resulted in the following outgoing voice message.

recording-20260302-120547

“I don’t recognize this number as a California pay phone in my database. If this is a real pay phone, contact me and I will look into it.”

Normal busy tones follow the recited message, given in a female voice.

Stop 2 Plan: Parkway Plaza (415 Fletcher Pkwy, El Cajon). The biggest mall in East County. Check near entrances and exterior bus stops.

Stop 2 Reality: Malls have so many card and game stores. They snuck in and took up residence after the significant downturn in mall life. And there are whole ass gotchapon salons now. I’m on board with this trend, although most of the gotchapon inventory is counterfeit Labubus and Baby Threes. We parked in the East Garage, walked through JC Penny, where they were actively repairing the ceilings with convex tarp drainage lashed up to trash cans with garden hose. Do Not Inventory (DNI) signs were taped to the faces of all the mannequins, and no one was shopping at all, and I had a flashback to Night of the Comet mall scenes, and Prey Animal was right: The “Do not lock during business hours” doors on the second floor were all solidly locked.

We escaped going back to the ground floor then walked away opposite from the parking deck entrance. This did take us to the ground floor of the main mall. Staff in JC Penny were cheerful and greeted us while we were walking swiftly everywhere else except towards their departments.

The food court had claw machines but no pay phones. We walked the outer perimeter of the entire mall. We found admin, we found security. No staff at either place. Neither responded to a door bell. Prey Animal vetoed simply going back through the doors. We started shopping instead.

One of the Lunch Box staff member recommended to check the Food Court for pay phones. I told them I was on a payphone scavenger hunt for my kid at SDSU. We checked the food court (and the movie theater, since they

used to have pay phones a long time ago) again. Nothing found.

But, usually, transit places have pay phones. There just had to be a bus stop here at this massive mall, but nothing showed up on Google Maps or with a basic web search. So I just Arkansas'd my way to the exterior bus stop. And then started wandering around. I found some infrastructure, at least, and something that looked like an old port.

FIRE ALARM CONTROL PANEL
PHONE
9

Terminal Locat

At this point, Prey Animal said “Don’t touch it in case it’s a needle. But if it’s a Geocache, pull it out and let’s log it.”

Thanks Prey.

Hmmm. Ok moving on.

Stop 3 Plan: El Cajon Transit Center at 352 South Marshall Avenue. A Google reviewer mentions the pay phones, so confidence is high. We will check the trolley platform and the bus bays.

Stop 3 Reality: Prey Animal refused to get out of the car. Felt like home to me so I sauntered over. The variety store at the transit station had a single payphone on the wall.

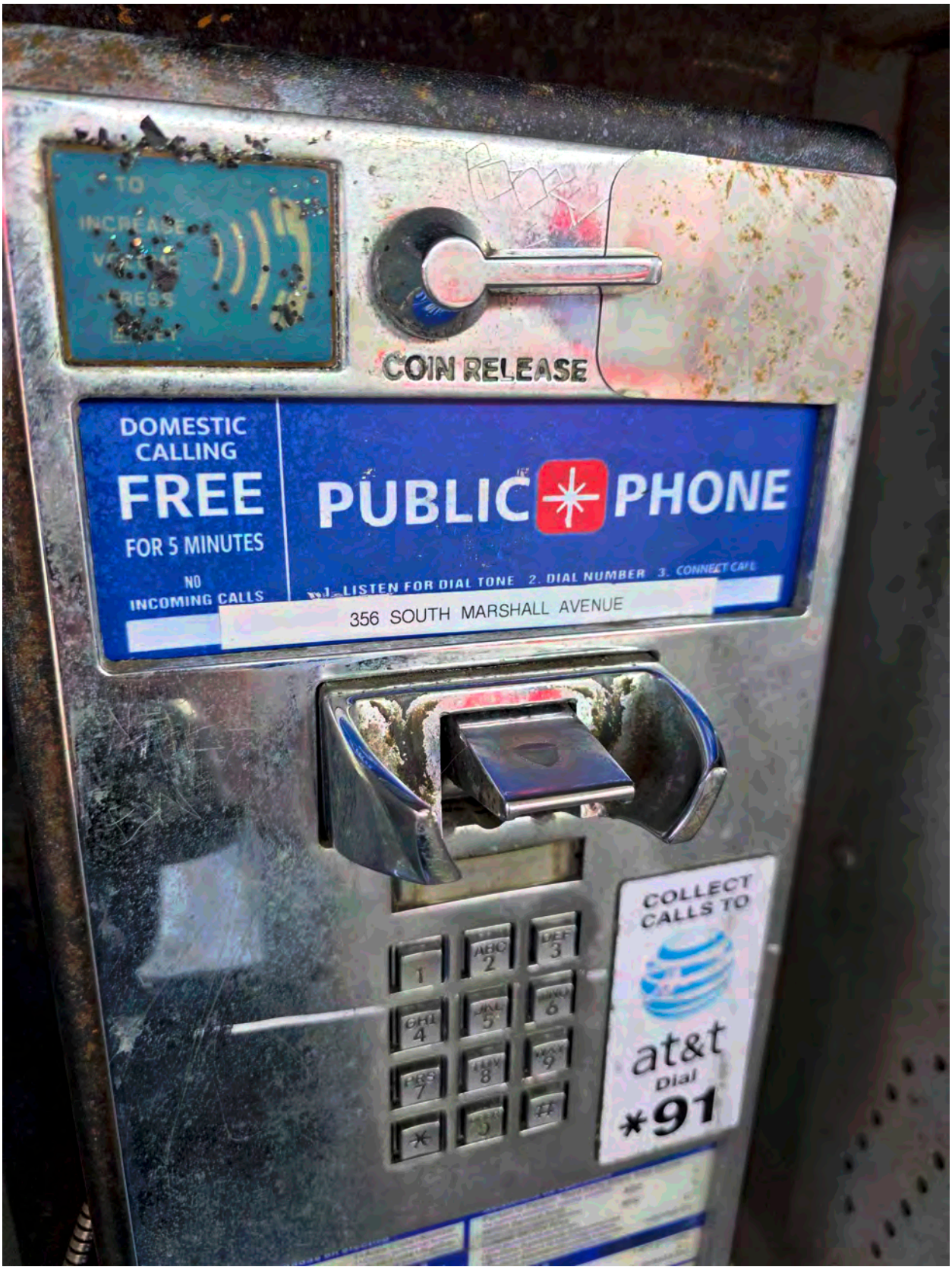
FREE
SHIKWARI

COIN RELEASE
PUBLIC PHONE
1. LISTEN FOR DIAL TONE 2. DIAL NUMBER 3. CONNECT CALL
356 SOUTH MARSHALL AVENUE
MINUTES
ING CALLS
COLLE
CALLS

Got a dial tone. Tried the game, got the same recording as heard from Stop 1.

Looked around. Up on the platform, could clearly see another payphone. Crossed the bus drive, climbed the stairs, found two phones. Some dude was standing really close to them (on his cell phone) but I sidled up and tried the payphone on the left. It was dead. No address sticker on that one. Gently reached around and picked up the other one, at a 90 degree angle, on the right. Dial tone, and address sticker. Took a photo of that one.

PACIFIC BELL
PACIFIC BELL
FREE
PUBLIC PHONE


TO
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CALLS TO
at&t
Dial
*91

Tried the game, got the same recording.

The Report:

Abraxas3d and Prey Animal tried three targets on a list of eight. No phone found at stop 2, but we found some evidence of a phone installed in the past possibly near the bus stop. Phone at stop 1 and some of the phones at stop 3 were live, and both sites gave the same error message. We recorded the outgoing message and took photos of the pay phones.

The Opinion:

I suspect these San Diego pay phones might have been converted to VoIP and the number they're registered under is not the number that is reported from Caller ID.

That means that the number we're calling from doesn't match the California Public Utilities Commission (CPUC) database.

The game works by caller ID. When we dial (888) 683-6697, the system sees the number we're calling FROM and matches it against the CPUC database. If the pay phones have been converted to VoIP or their numbers have changed, the caller ID won't match.

The site even acknowledges this possibility in their FAQ. CPUC-licensed pay phones get switched to different underlying services by COCOT operators, changing the outgoing caller ID. So, we'll reach out to hello@walzr.com with these details so they can investigate further.

Why switch to VoIP?

Session Initiation Protocol (SIP) trunking is cheaper than maintaining plain old telephone service (POTS) lines for a payphone. Analog POTS lines do not exist any more in most places. The new provider assigns different DIDs (virtual phone number) than what was originally registered with the CPUC. The license filing probably hasn't been updated because… well, why would a payphone operator bother updating paperwork for a dying business?

Another possibility is that the phones were renumbered during the 619/858 overlay consolidation or through carrier porting, and the CPUC records still reflect the old numbers. This is much less likely because that was a long time ago, but deserves a check.

Or, there's just a simple bug in the game.

We recorded the outgoing message and took a photo of the phones.

But, there's actually a way to make a payphone report the number it thinks it has.

Round Two:

3 March 2026

Abraxas3d and Skunkwrx with Odessa

We returned to the pay phones we found on 2 March and attempted the following techniques.

First! The Universal Method:

Call an ANAC Number. ANAC stands for Automatic Number Announcement Circuit.

1-800-444-4444: This is a widely functional MCI toll-free service that often works on almost all carriers to read back the number of the line you are calling from.

SBC
SBC
SBC
PUBLIC PHONE
at&t
+91

1-800-444-2222 or 1-800-323-9393 are alternative toll-free test numbers.

Pick up the handset, dial the number (no coins usually required), and a recorded voice states the phone number. This used to be followed by a ringback, but payphone stopped taking incoming calls a while ago.

Second! The *5055 Code:

In many areas, especially with TelCo-owned pay phones, dialing *5055 will initiate a ringback, which can sometimes be used to identify the line.

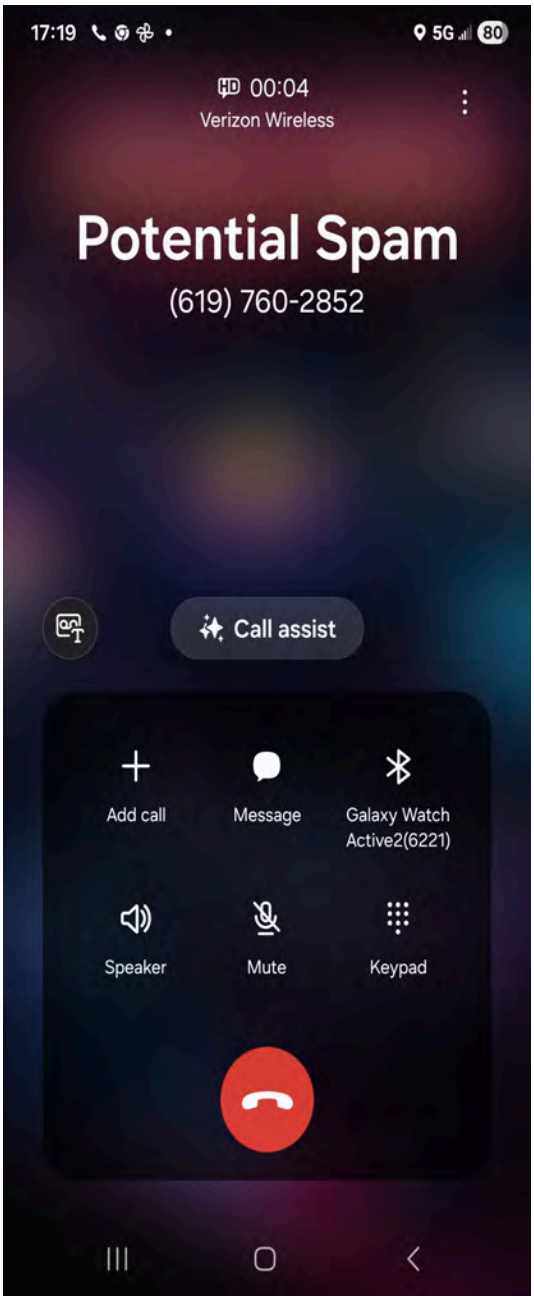
Third! Pay for a call and call a cell phone you have access to. Many pay phones in San Diego are now free for the first five minutes of a domestic call, so you can simply lift the handset and place a domestic call. We know Caller ID can be spoofed, but we at least get the cover number.

Results:

Here are the results from 3 March 2026.

Stop 1:

Turns out there's two pay phones at this trolley station and not just one. The ANAC number worked, and the phone number was 619 760 2852. The automated service asks if this is the number expected, allows you to enter the number you're calling from if it is different from the number returned by ANAC, and gives you some additional limited options, including a way to request phone service. The number recited back was also the number returned by ANAC at the second payphone. In other words, they both had the same number. Calling Abraxas3d cell phone gave the same number ANAC returned on the mobile's caller ID, along with a Spam Risk alert.



Stop 3:

The two working pay phones at the El Cajon Transit Center both responded to the standard ANAC number and both returned a phone number of 619 760 2842. Quite similar to the Santee trolley stop pay phones. Calling Skunkwrx's phone gave the same number in Caller ID.

To be continued!

We have emailed hello@walzr.com with this report. The pay phone did not have their own number displayed. Only the address. If the numbers we found for the addresses given match, then there might be a bug in the game. If the numbers do not match, then the database fetched has errors.

The Payphone Go site does say they will try to fix mismatches if we give them the details. Maybe we can get the whole San Diego region working for everyone else, basically doing a site survey for the game.

If you have any additional results, please share and bring to 11 March DEFCON meetup. Would be super fun to get this working. After all, pay phones are the only way we can escape the Matrix.

-Abraxas3d

-Prey Animal

-Skunkwrx

Special thanks to Odessa for transportation